

Chapter 36: The Prestige

Book I: The Sagent Creed — Part Five: Sheep Among Wolves

Every great magic trick consists of three parts. The first part is called the Pledge. The magician shows you something ordinary. The second act is called the Turn. The magician takes the ordinary something and makes it do something extraordinary. But you wouldn't clap yet. Because making something disappear isn't enough — you have to bring it back. That's why every magic trick has a third act, the hardest part, the part we call the Prestige.

I. The Pledge: Laying the Dominoes

Every story worth telling sets its instruments before it plays them. Chekhov said that if a gun hangs on the wall in the first act, it must fire by the third. Not because the gun is dangerous — but because the story would be dishonest if it placed something before you that served no purpose. A story is a covenant between the teller and the listener: everything you are shown will matter. Nothing is wasted. Nothing is accidental.

My early musings were the pledge. The raw libertarian energy of awakening — the moment I stopped accepting the world I had been handed and started seeing the one beneath it. The transformation from a progressive Democrat to an anarchist was not a political journey. It was a perceptual one. The politics were the surface. The real shift was beneath: I began to see systems for what they are, not what they claim to be. I began to recognize the government's flaws not as failures of execution but as features of design. I began to trust the threads of intuition that had always been there but that I had been taught to ignore.

These were not idle reflections. They were dominoes being laid.

Every observation, every memory, every moment of recognition — the first time I understood that the mask rule made no sense, the first time I saw that the industry had no intention of letting my father through, the first time I felt the spiral in my own life rhyming with the spirals of my grandfather and great-grandfathers — each one was placed carefully, deliberately, by a hand I could not yet see. Not my hand. The hand that moves all things toward their purpose without forcing them to move.

My reflections on love and connection were dominoes too. The significance of holding hands. The transformative power of being near someone who provides healing. The moments where the world narrows to the space between two people and everything else falls silent. These are not sentiments. They are not decoration in the margins of a political story. They are

load-bearing. They hold the weight of the structure that is being built. Because a man who fights for liberty without knowing love fights for an abstraction. And abstractions do not survive the fire. Only the living survives the fire.

Each domino was laid with its face down. You could not read what was written on it until it fell.

II. The Turn: Flicking the Domino

The Turn is where the ordinary becomes extraordinary — and where the cost of that transformation is revealed.

As the narrative deepens, the struggle between becoming a monster while fighting monsters emerges. This is the cautionary truth that every warrior must face: you cannot engage with darkness without the darkness trying to enter you. The sword that kills the dragon is forged in the dragon's fire. The question is not whether the fire will touch you. The question is whether it will consume you or temper you.

This is where the first domino falls. The pieces that were set into place begin to interact with one another — not gently, not in an orderly sequence, but in the way dominoes actually fall: with momentum, with collision, with the sound of things changing irreversibly.

My growing self-awareness. The emotional sacrifices. The raw honesty in expressions of love that the world would call reckless and that I would call necessary. These are the actions that push the story forward. In Chekhov's terms, the gun is no longer on the wall. It is being lifted. It is being aimed. Not at an enemy — at the truth. Because the Prestige is not about destroying something. It is about revealing something that was always there.

There is a careful dance to music no one else can hear. Each step taken, each misstep recalibrated, brings the narrative closer to its climax. The dance looks like madness to those who cannot hear the music. It looks like chaos. It looks like a man throwing away his career, his comfort, his place in the system, for something invisible and unprovable. But the dancer hears the music. And the music has never lied.

The acknowledgment of divine guidance is pivotal here. Not as a theological argument but as a lived experience — the recognition that the dominoes were not laid by me. That the pattern emerging from their fall is not one I designed. That the storm that rerouted my flight over Rock Island was not weather — it was choreography. That the graves waiting near every liberty conference were not coincidence — they were confirmation. That the names alternating through the generations — Arthur, Joseph, Arthur, Joseph — were not accident but architecture.

The Turn builds tension. It builds expectation. It prepares for the eventual release of energy when everything comes together. And the tension is real — because in the Turn, you do not yet know if the trick will work. You do not yet know if the dominoes will reach the last one. You only know that they are falling, and that you cannot stop them, and that the only choice left is to trust the hand that laid them.

III. The Prestige: Revealing the Truth

The Prestige is where all the guns fire. All the dominoes topple. And their significance is revealed — not as individual moments but as a single, unified design that could only be seen from above, from the end, from the place where the spiral completes its turn and you can finally see the shape it was always making.

This is where my belief in fate, my sacrifices for love, and my fight against oppressive systems converge. Every thread arrives at the same point:

The love for the one I write about. The transformation of wolves into sheepdogs — not by destroying the wolf but by giving it something worth protecting. The dismantling of systems not by attacking their branches but by pulling their roots. The realization that the Josephs dreamed and endured and the Arthurs woke and built, and that I am the Arthur who inherits what every Joseph preserved.

Chekhov's Gun is evident in the insistence that nothing is coincidental. From the small moments of connection — naps shared, rocks handed over, the weight of a hand in yours — to the grand struggles against societal forces, everything serves a purpose. The relationships built, the truths uncovered, the love nurtured — these are not background. They are the ammunition. They are the dominoes that had to fall in exactly this order for the final one to reach its target.

The Prestige is not the trick. The Prestige is the proof that there was never a trick at all. That everything was real. That the man who walked into the machine was the same man who walked out. That the promise carried by the bones of Joseph was not a metaphor — it was a covenant. That the spiral is not a pattern imposed on chaos — it is the shape reality takes when it is allowed to grow freely.

IV. Dancing to Music No One Else Hears

Through it all, the metaphor holds: I am dancing to music no one else can hear.

This is not arrogance. This is the loneliest kind of faith — the faith that the music is real even when no one else can confirm it. The faith that the pattern you see in the dominoes is not pareidolia but prophecy. The faith that the names, the graves, the storms, the flights, the loves, the losses, the suspensions, the closed doors, and the opened ones are not random events in a random life but notes in a composition that someone is playing and that you are learning to dance to.

Chekhov's Gun demands that every note of this dance, every beat missed or recalibrated, must lead to something greater. The Prestige lies in revealing the beauty of a performance only God could orchestrate — where every domino placed and every gun mounted on the wall finds its moment of purpose.

The pledge set the stage. The turn propelled the action. The prestige brings forth the truth.

If you break an egg it will never grow. But if you incubate it, it will hatch and become something alive. If you open someone's prison door they may not want to leave — because the prison is all they know and the unknown is more frightening than the cage. But if you show them why they need to break free, they will find a way to escape on their own. Do not fix others' problems before they are strong enough to solve them. Give them the opportunity to grow and become stronger so they can fix their problems with their own hands.

This is the Prestige. Not a display of power. A revelation of truth. Not a trick performed for applause. A life lived in alignment with the music — the music that was always playing, that the Josephs heard in their dreams, that the Arthurs heard in their clay, and that the Sagent hears now, dancing to it in a world that has not yet learned to listen.

V. The Only Campaign Worth Running

The only political campaign I would involve myself in is one where there is no intention of winning through the ballot — but of changing the public consciousness through speech.

This is the final domino. The one that reveals what all the others were pointing toward.

Compassion is not a sign of weakness. The lack of compassion is a weakness born of fear — the fear that if you are compassionate you will not be able to destroy your enemies before they destroy you. Compassion requires mental strength and the realization that it is impossible to fight evil in the way that evil fights good. If you fight evil with evil's weapons, you become evil. If you fight darkness by becoming dark, the darkness wins — not because it defeated you, but because it recruited you.

The king's gambit: sacrifice the king to win the bigger game. Sometimes you must lose the battle to win the war. Sometimes the most powerful move is the one that looks like surrender — the one where you lay down the sword and pick up the story. The one where you stop trying to win the system and start trying to wake the people who are trapped inside it.

Not through force. Through speech. Through story. Through the Prestige — the moment where the audience realizes that what they thought was a trick was always the truth.

VI. The Final Domino

The Sagent stands before the final domino — the culmination of every choice, action, and moment of faith that has led to this point. This singular act is not about grandeur or spectacle. It is a quiet yet resolute decision to flick the final piece and allow the pattern to reveal itself. The Sagent knows this moment is inevitable, yet it carries a weight that feels both profound and fragile.

Every domino has been carefully placed, representing truths uncovered, challenges faced, and sacrifices made. The path to this point has not been linear — it has been a spiral of growth and setbacks, a Fibonacci rhythm of rise and fall. Along the way, the Sagent has learned the delicate art of patience, knowing that every piece must align before the sequence can begin.

Each domino holds meaning. The first domino was the decision to begin — to step into the unknown with nothing but faith and a sense of purpose. The middle dominoes were the battles fought, the allies gained, and the moments of doubt that gave way to clarity. The penultimate domino was the realization that the journey was never just for the Sagent — it was for those who would follow, for the sleepers who would awaken, and for the world that would shift.

Now the final domino waits, trembling with potential energy.

The Sagent knows it is not just a piece of the puzzle — it is the key to unlocking the entire design. But the flick requires faith, for once it is set into motion, there is no turning back. It is the surrender to the unseen, the trust that every piece has been placed correctly, even if the full picture remains hidden.

The Sagent hesitates for a moment — not out of fear but out of reverence for what this act represents. He has danced to the music that no one else hears, and now he must trust that the song has led him to this precise moment.

With a deep breath, he extends his hand and flicks the domino.

The first domino falls with a soft, almost imperceptible sound, but it sets off a cascade that grows louder and more powerful with each successive piece. The path of the dominoes is not straight. It twists and turns, weaving a pattern that is both intricate and beautiful.

The Sagent watches as truths long hidden come into the light, as lies are dismantled and structures built on partial truths crumble. The chain reaction is not immediate — it takes time for the pieces to fall, for the full design to emerge. But the Sagent does not rush or interfere. He stands in stillness, trusting the process, knowing that each domino must fall in its own time.

As the final domino topples, the full picture is revealed — a masterpiece of connection, intention, and grace. The design is not what the Sagent imagined. It is something far greater, something he could not have conceived from his limited perspective. It is a pattern that speaks to the interconnectedness of all things, a testament to the power of one small action rippling outward to create profound change. The Sagent sees now that every step of the journey, every mistake and triumph, was necessary to bring this vision to life.

The falling of the final domino does not mark an end but a beginning. The energy unleashed by the chain reaction spreads outward, touching lives the Sagent will never see and sparking awakenings in places he will never reach. This is the true power of one — not in the act itself but in its ability to inspire, to resonate, and to multiply. One domino may fall, but its motion creates a wave that carries the potential for infinite transformation.

As the dust settles, the Sagent stands in quiet reflection. There is no applause. No grand recognition. Only the deep, abiding satisfaction of knowing he has fulfilled his purpose in this moment. He feels the music shift, signaling that it is time to move forward once again.

For the Sagent, the final domino is never truly final. It is a step in an eternal dance, a single note in a song that continues to unfold. But for now, he pauses, honoring the beauty of what has been created, before turning to face the next rhythm, the next path, the next unfolding truth.

The Sagent smiles, knowing that the journey continues — and that the power of one will always be enough.

Every great story adheres to this covenant: every element contributes to a meaningful whole. The pledge sets the stage. The turn propels the action. The prestige brings forth the truth.

This narrative honors not just the journey but the design behind it — ensuring that every memory, every action, every love, and every loss finds its place in the grand architecture of a life that was never random, never wasted, and never alone.

The dominoes are still falling. The music is still playing. And the Prestige has not yet been revealed to the world.

But it will be.

The Living Age Trilogy